



Horizon Europe European Research Council (ERC)

Guide for Reviewers Proof of Concept Grant Calls



European Research Council
Executive Agency

Established by the European Commission

Version 5.0
February 2026

HISTORY OF CHANGES		
Version	Publication Date	Description
1.0	19.10.2021	Guide for Reviewers – Proof of Concept Grant 2022 Calls
2.0	02.02.2023	Guide for Reviewers – Proof of Concept Grant 2023 Calls
3.0	14.03.2024	Guide for Reviewers – Proof of Concept Grant 2024 Calls
4.0	25.03.2025	Guide for Reviewers – Proof of Concept Grant 2025 Calls
5.0	06.02.2026	Guide for Reviewers – Proof of Concept Grant 2026 Calls, with update of the duration for a PoC project to eighteen months, in accordance with the amended ERC Work Programme 2026 .



European Research Council
Executive Agency

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European Research Council (ERC)

Guide for Reviewers

**Applicable to the ERC Proof of Concept Grants
(ERC Work Programme 2026)**

Version 5.0
January 2026



This document is published by the ERC Scientific Council on the [ERC website](#). It can also be downloaded from the [EU Funding & Tenders Portal](#) (Single Electronic Data Interchange Area (SEDIA)).

IMPORTANT TO NOTE

This Guide for Reviewers is based on legal documents setting the rules and conditions for the ERC frontier research grants, in particular:

- The [ERC Work Programme 2026](#)¹, which defines, inter alia, the main features of the Call for Proposals for ERC Proof of Concept Grants, including the call deadlines or cut-off dates and the call budget. It specifies the evaluation criterion and sets the framework for budgetary implementation. The selection of proposals for funding by the European Research Council (ERC) Proof of Concept Grants is based strictly on the evaluation criterion set in the relevant ERC Work Programme.
- The [ERC Rules of submission and evaluation under Horizon Europe](#), which establish the rules applying to the submission of proposals and the related evaluation process, selection and award procedures relevant to the [Specific Programme of Horizon Europe](#) – the Framework programme for Research and Innovation (2021-2027).
- The [Contract for ERC Experts](#), which defines the relationship between the ERC Executive Agency (ERCEA) and the independent external experts ('experts'). Signature of this contract by the expert indicates acceptance of the conditions regarding confidentiality and conflict of interest ([Code of Conduct to the Model Contract for Experts](#)), and use of personal data by the ERCEA².

This document complements and does not supersede the aforementioned documents, which are legally binding and prevail in case of any discrepancies. This guide specifies in more detail the evaluation process, its inputs and outputs, and the responsibilities of the participants in the process. It provides further details on certain provisions of the [ERC Rules of submission and evaluation under Horizon Europe](#), such as the management of conflict of interest.

The European Commission, the ERCEA or any person or body acting on their behalf cannot be held responsible for the use made of this document.

Abbreviations

AC - [Associated Country](#)

ER - Evaluation Report

ERC - [European Research Council](#)

ERCEA - [ERC Executive Agency](#)

ERC WP - [ERC Work Programme](#)

F&T portal - [EU Funding & Tenders Portal](#) [Single Electronic Data Interchange Area (SEDIA)]

HI - Host Institution

PI - Principal Investigator

PM - Panel Member

PoC - [Proof of Concept](#)

SEP - [Submission and Evaluation of Proposals System](#)

ScC - [ERC Scientific Council](#)

¹ European Commission Implementing Decision C(2026)62 of 15 January 2026, amending Implementing Decision C(2025) 5000 of 8 July 2025 .

² The personal data are processed in accordance with Regulation (EU) No 2018/1725.

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1. EVALUATION OF POC PROPOSALS

The ERC Proof of Concept Grant is a complementary funding only on offer to Principal Investigators that already benefit from an ERC main research grant (Starting Grant, Consolidator Grant, Advanced Grant or Synergy Grant). Frontier research often generates radically new ideas that drive innovation and business inventiveness and tackle societal challenges. The ERC PoC Grants aim at facilitating exploration of the commercial and social innovation potential of ERC funded research.

1.1. REVIEWERS

The [Contract for ERC Experts](#) defines the relationship between the ERC Executive Agency (ERCEA) and the independent external experts ('experts'). By signing this document, the expert accepts the conditions regarding confidentiality and conflict of interest, and use of personal data by the ERCEA³. The ERCEA cannot make proposals available to an expert who has not been officially contracted.

A breach of the [Expert Code of Conduct](#) or other serious misconduct by an independent external expert may be qualified as grave professional misconduct and may lead to the termination of the contract.

1.2. CONFLICTS OF INTEREST AND CONFIDENTIALITY

Experts should not be put in a situation in which their impartiality might be questioned, or where the suspicion could arise that recommendations are affected by elements that lie outside the scope of the review. Furthermore, reviewers should not engage in any contact with applicants or beneficiaries (affiliated entities or other third parties involved in the proposals/actions or team members or persons linked to them) about the evaluation, in which they are participating (neither during nor after the evaluation is over).

A list of conflicts of interests (see below) will be displayed in the on-line evaluation system, and the experts will be asked to confirm the absence of conflict of interests when accepting to review and when submitting their individual review. Based on the information available, the ERC PoC call coordinator shall avoid assigning proposals to experts who have a conflict of interest. Please note that it is always the responsibility of the expert to declare the conflict of interest.

List of conflicts of interests displayed in the on-line evaluation system⁴:

- I am PI or team member in the proposal (or any other proposal submitted to the same call).
- I was involved in the preparation of the proposal (or any other proposal submitted to the same panel).
- I would benefit should the proposal (or any other proposal submitted to the same panel) be accepted or rejected.
- I am employed or contracted by one of the entities involved in the proposal (applicant, affiliated entity, named subcontractor or other participant involved in the proposal) or have been so in the past 3 years.

³ The personal data are processed in accordance with Regulation (EU) No 2018/1725.

⁴ Please note that the above-mentioned briefly outlined examples of the conflict of interest situations are fully described in the [Code of Conduct](#) for EU experts including the actions that the ERCEA might put in place in order to ensure the strict impartiality of evaluations.

- I am a director, trustee or partner or involved in the management of any entity involved in the proposal (applicant, affiliated entity or other participant involved in the proposal) or have been so in the past 3 years.
- I am collaborating scientifically - or have done so in the past 5 years - with the PI.
- I have (or have had) a mentor/mentee relationship with the PI.
- I have family ties or close personal relationship with the PI (or any PI submitting a proposal to the same panel).
- I have family ties or close personal relationship with anyone who was involved in the preparation of the proposal (or any other proposal submitted to the same panel).
- I have family ties or close personal relationship with anyone who would benefit from the proposal being granted (or from any other proposal submitted to the same panel being granted) or rejected.
- I am (or was) in a relationship of scientific rivalry or hostility with the PI.
- I am a National Contact Point or working for the Enterprise Europe Network (EEN).
- I am a member of an EU programme committee.
- I am in any other situation that would preclude the impartial review of the proposal or that could appear to do so.

1.3. ROLES OF ERC REVIEWERS

ERC Panel - In the context of the PoC evaluation process, given that it does not involve any scientific evaluation per se, experts are grouped in a single evaluation panel. An ERC PoC panel differs from other ERC evaluation panels in several ways: it is composed of a pool of experts who do not necessarily have similar professional background and it is not chaired by a Panel Chair. The PoC experts are selected by the ERC Scientific Council on the basis of their expertise in technology transfer and social innovation. The size of the panel might be increased if the demand of the PoC call increases.

ERC PoC experts - The experts make a significant commitment of their time to the ERC review process. They perform the following tasks:

- Individual review – by electronic means – of a subset of the proposals (remote work).
- Participation in the initial panel meeting and, if necessary, in an additional panel meeting.
- Prior familiarisation with a relevant subset of proposals in preparation for the meeting (in case an additional panel meeting is needed).

Use of personal data - All experts involved in the evaluation of proposals must keep in mind that any personal data received are only to be used for the purposes for which they are transmitted. All unnecessary and excessive information submitted by applicants should be disregarded.

Publication of Panel Members names - The names of all the Panel Members participating in the PoC evaluation are published on the ERC website after the evaluation process is concluded and the final results have been communicated to all applicants.

1.4. ROLE OF OBSERVERS

The ERC Scientific Council – The ERC Scientific Council may delegate its members to be present during the panel meetings⁵ as observers. The role of these delegates is to ensure and promote coherence of evaluations, to identify best practices and to gather information for future reviews of the procedures by the ERC Scientific Council. In conformity with the mandate of the ERC Scientific

⁵ at the Initial Panel Meeting or in the rare cases where a panel meeting needs to be organized.

Council to carry out the scientific governance of the ERC and in line with the role of the ERC ScC foreseen in the [ERC Rules of submission and evaluation under Horizon Europe](#)⁶ ERC ScC members will abstain from influencing the results of the evaluation process.

Independent observers - Independent external experts may be appointed as observers to examine the evaluation process from the point of view of its working and execution. The Independent Observers are external to the ERCEA or the ERC Scientific Council. Their function and role is described in section 3.4 [of the ERC Rules of submission and evaluation under Horizon Europe](#).

2. EVALUATION CRITERION

2.1. ADMISSIBILITY AND ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA

Admissibility and eligibility criteria⁷ are simple, factual and legally binding. Their assessment does not involve technical or scientific judgement and hence they are not part of the review process. Instead, the assessment of admissibility and eligibility of submitted proposals is carried out by the ERCEA staff. Nevertheless, if an expert considers a proposal to be potentially inadmissible (incomplete proposal because sections are missing) or ineligible during the evaluation process they should clarify the case immediately with the ERC PoC call coordinator. In some rare cases, proposals may be declared inadmissible or ineligible during or even after the evaluation process, if it becomes clear that one or more of the admissibility or eligibility criteria have not been or are no longer met.

2.2. EVALUATION CRITERION AND ELEMENTS

The evaluation criterion and evaluation elements as well as their interpretation are described in the [ERC Work Programme 2026](#) and are at the core of the evaluation process. All judgement on proposals must be made against the evaluation elements and against these evaluation elements alone.

The sole evaluation criterion of excellence consists of the following evaluation elements:

Project

1.a Breakthrough innovation potential

1.b Approach and methodology

Principal Investigator

1.c Strategic lead and project management

Independent external experts will evaluate independently each admissible and eligible proposal and mark it as 'very good', 'good' or 'fail' for each of the three evaluation elements. In order to be considered for funding, proposals will have to be awarded a pass mark ('very good' or 'good') by a majority of independent external experts on each of the three evaluation elements.

The incorrect application of an evaluation element or the application of an inexistent or irrelevant evaluation element is considered a procedural error, which may justify a re-evaluation of the proposal.

⁶ See section 3.4

⁷ See Admissibility and eligibility criteria of the [ERC Work Programme 2026](#).

3. INDIVIDUAL REVIEWS

Individual reviews are carried out remotely by the deadline set by the ERC PoC call coordinator. All experts participate in the individual remote review stage.

Minimum requirements - In the PoC scheme, each proposal is evaluated by at least 3 experts. If a panel meeting takes place, each proposal is assigned to a “lead reviewer” who introduces the proposal to the panel for discussion and is responsible for drafting the panel comment⁸.

Expected reviewers’ confidentiality - During the individual remote evaluation process, there shall be no discussions of the proposals between experts. Moreover, experts should not disclose the proposals assigned for their evaluation to other experts. When experts consider that they have insufficient expertise to evaluate any of the proposals assigned to them, they should immediately inform the ERCEA PoC call coordinator so that the proposal can be reallocated to another expert.

3.1. MARKS AND COMMENTS

An individual evaluation of a PoC proposal consists of:

- Awarding a pass mark (‘very good’ or ‘good’) or a fail mark (‘fail’) for each of the evaluation elements⁹. It is of utmost importance that only the sole evaluation criterion of excellence broken down into the three evaluation elements as described in the [ERC WP 2026](#) is used to assess the proposals. Experts should refrain from using any additional criteria or evaluation element(s) no matter the importance it bears in the frame of a given proposal. Each proposal should be treated with the same severity and professionalism (equal treatment).
- Providing a succinct explanatory comment substantiating each mark. Comments should take the form of a statement and explanation of key strengths and key weaknesses of the proposal, in the light of the evaluation elements. The marks should be consistent with the comments.

3.2. QUALITY STANDARDS OF INDIVIDUAL REVIEWERS’ COMMENTS

Comments should be provided by each expert for each evaluation element of the proposal. All the individual reviewers’ comments are included in the Evaluation Report and as such reproduced in the feedback to applicants. Reviewers should therefore take care in formulating their comments in the individual assessments.

The individual comments should be of high quality, genuine, succinct but substantial. They should also be polite. A decision of the expert to attribute a “fail” mark shall be explained in detail in order for the applicant to be able to understand the weaknesses of their proposal, so as to seek effective remedy for any future applications. Likewise, in case of a “good” mark, the applicant should be put in a position to understand why the expert did not award a “very good” mark.

Experts need to observe the following guidelines:

- Provide substantial, explanatory comments; avoid comments that merely give a description or a summary of the proposal.
- Use dispassionate, analytical and unambiguous language.

⁸ The panel comment is part of the “Evaluation Report” which is sent to the applicant as feedback.

⁹ See [ERC Work Programme 2026](#).

- Use grammatically correct, complete, clear sentences with no jargon.
- Provide respectful and polite comments.
- Be constructive and not offensive if providing critical comments.
- Avoid self-declaration of insufficient expertise (personal or panel) in the proposal.
- Avoid any comments about your expertise that may reveal your identity.
- Do not make any reference to the applicant's age, nationality, gender, or personal matters.
- Avoid making reference to marks in the comments.
- Avoid inconsistency between the nature of the comment and the mark attributed.
- Be aware of unconscious bias in aspects such as gender and diversity more broadly¹⁰
- Avoid any comments on PI's past, current or future Host Institution; its standing is not an ERC evaluation criterion.
- Avoid any comparison with any other proposals.
- Avoid any reference or comparison with previous assessments in case of a resubmitted proposal.
- Avoid dismissive statements about the Principal Investigator or the project. Keep in mind that previous experience in innovation is not required for the Principal Investigator. Avoid very short comments, especially in the case of a "fail" mark.
- Double check after submitting the review if the mark appearing for each element assessed corresponds to the intended mark.
- Avoid comments on the ethical and security aspects of the proposal. Ethical and security clearance is performed by the ERCEA and respective EU institutions for all fundable proposals.
- Avoid any reference to costs, budget figures when assessing the description of resources (see below).

Individual reviews have to be submitted in due time according to the deadline set by the ERCEA PoC call coordinator.

3.3. OTHER ASPECTS OF THE EVALUATION

Ressources assessment - Experts should pay particular attention to the evaluation element "Approach and methodology" due to the fact that the grants to be awarded under the Proof of Concept Call take the form of a standard lump sum pre-fixed at EUR 150 000¹¹ for a period of eighteen months¹². The lump sum is deemed to cover all eligible (direct and indirect) costs for the

¹⁰ It has been shown that unconscious bias applies equally, regardless of the reviewers' gender. Whereas possible gender biases may be rooted in the institutions or the community where the applicants may come from, a wealth of evidence points at possible introduction of unconscious biases in evaluation processes (see the [ERC unconscious bias briefing](#)). Experts are requested to be vigilant and aware, so such elements are not introduced in the evaluation process.

¹¹ In accordance with the [Decision authorising the use of lump sums for the European Research Council Proof of Concept actions under the Horizon Europe Programme](#) – the Framework Programme for Research and Innovation.

¹² In accordance with the [ERC Work Programme 2026](#), PoC project will be awarded for a period of eighteen months.

action and it cannot be increased or decreased. The Principal Investigator must demonstrate that the proposed timescales and resources are adequate and properly justified, which is part of evaluation element 1.b. The applicant is expected to provide a **narrative description** of the resources planned for each activity. Examples of resources that the applicant is expected to describe are the type of staff working on a task and the estimated effort (person-months), the type of equipment and consumables required for the project implementation, staff travel requirements, etc. **The applicants are specifically requested not to describe the resources financially**, which means that **no cost figures should appear in the proposal**. The applicants are expected to justify the good use of the lump sum for the resources needed for the project. In case a proposal includes budget figures, cost details etc., they shall be disregarded by the expert and the applicant shall not be penalised for this. The expert shall refrain from assessing budget and costs figures, and shall avoid any reference to them in their assessment. However, when a proposal does not include sufficient details about the resources eventough the budget and cost details are disregarded, the expert can comment on this deficiency in their individual review.

Letters of support or intent - Experts have access to the annexes of PoC proposals containing Letters of support or intent from relevant stakeholders. If such contacts already exist, applicants are asked to include them to document section 1b.ii - description of PoC activities (see [Part B template](#)).

Ethics and Security - Experts should disregard any Ethics and Security issues annexes, as Ethical clearance is performed by the ERCEA and Security clearance by the European Commission for all proposals selected for funding. Experts should avoid comments on the ethical aspects of the proposal, except in the case of potential use of hESC (human Embryonic Stem Cells) which should be flagged and reported to the ERC PoC call coordinator because these aspects might need further consultation. If one of the PoC activities involves hESCs, the experts involved in the evaluation of the proposal should confirm whether the use of hESCs is necessary in order to achieve the objectives of the proposal.

NB: Annexes do not count towards the maximum page limit of Part B (10 pages, excluding the headers, the abstract, references and the risk mitigation table).

4. EVALUATION PROCESS (including panel meetings)

4.1 BRIEFING OF REVIEWERS

At the start of the evaluation session, experts are invited to the **Initial Panel Meeting**. The purpose of this meeting is two-fold: first to brief the experts on all relevant aspects of the evaluation processes and procedures, and second to exchange views with the ERCEA staff about the evaluation.

Experts are strongly encouraged to participate to this initial briefing.

The briefing covers matters such as the evaluation process and procedures, the content of topics under consideration, the terms of the experts' contract (including confidentiality, impartiality and conflict of interest rules), the completion of the tasks and approval of reports, the methodology to be followed and the possible consequences of non-compliance.

At the Initial Panel Meeting, ERCEA staff presents the methodology to be followed for the evaluation, marking and final ranking, and the experts agree to follow a remote evaluation process. If, as a result of the remote evaluation process, there is a tie between two or more proposals, a ranking methodology is also agreed ahead of time to break the tie. Experts are explicitly asked at the Initial Panel Meeting to agree to follow the methodology for the evaluation and ranking. This

agreement is asked explicitly and minuted. If such agreement is not reached, a final ranking meeting is offered.

4.2. REMOTE REVIEW AND RANKING OF PROPOSALS

Each proposal is evaluated by at least 3 experts who will mark it as 'very good', 'good' or 'fail' for each of the three evaluation elements (see section 2.3) **In order to be considered for funding, proposals will have to be awarded a pass mark by a majority of experts on each of the three evaluation elements.**

A proposal which fails overall one or more of the evaluation elements will not be ranked and will not be funded.

If there is not enough budget to fund all the proposals which pass all three evaluation elements, those proposals will be ranked according to the aggregated marks ('very good', 'good' and 'fail') they received from experts sorted by the following order: i) evaluation element 1.a Project - Breakthrough innovation potential; ii) evaluation element 1.b Project - Approach and methodology, and iii) evaluation element 1.c Principal Investigator - Strategic lead and project management. Proposals will be funded in order of the ranking resulting from this 3-level sorting exercise until depletion of the available budget per evaluation round. If necessary, experts will meet as an evaluation panel in order to determine a priority order for proposals which have the same ranking. Proposals that are recommended for funding but without sufficient available funds may be put on a reserve list and can be funded if additional budget becomes available.

As explained in section 4.1, if as a result of the remote evaluation process, there is a tie between two or more proposals, a ranking methodology agreed ahead of time at the Initial Panel Meeting to break the tie is applied.

The budget for the Proof of Concept call will be distributed evenly between the two evaluation rounds. Should additional budget credits become available, the ERC Scientific Council will set the rules for their allocation to the calls and evaluation rounds based on the assessment of scientific necessity, the volume of applications and the anticipated success rates of the calls or evaluation rounds.

The possible use of a voting system - In the later stages of the evaluation process, the panel may finalise their ranking process by the use of a voting system (e.g. a majority vote on one or more proposals, with each expert having one vote per proposal being considered). An expert cannot vote for a proposal if under a CoI, and in such case, an appropriate adjustment is applied. Voting can be an effective way of finalising a ranking list. If there is a group of equally ranked fundable proposals that crosses the budget cut off-line, the panel will proceed as follows:

- All the experts involved in the evaluation of at least one proposal in this group will be sent the reviews of all the proposals in the group taking into account the CoIs, without revealing the expert's identity.
- The experts will then examine all the proposals in the group and the existing reviews, and decide on their own personal ranking.
- The ERCEA will compile a sub-ranking within the group taking into account the CoIs, and will then come up with an overall final ranking list, for final endorsement by all experts.

The possible need of a panel meeting - Proposals will be funded in order of the ranking described below, up to depletion of the available budget. If necessary, the experts will meet as an evaluation

panel in order to determine a priority order for proposals which have the same ranking. A Panel meeting will hence only be held if there is any ambiguity on the list of proposals to be considered for funding. Otherwise, the determination of the priority order for proposals which have the same ranking will be carried out remotely.

Endorsement of the ranking list - After the individual remote evaluation phase, the final ranking order is sent to the experts for their information and endorsement. The endorsement takes place electronically in the evaluation IT system. During this phase, the experts may consult and check their scores and comments for the reviewed proposals against the ranked list. The ranked list shows the accumulated scores for each proposal from all experts involved in the evaluation of the proposal concerned. Although experts cannot see comments and direct scores of the other experts, they can deduct other experts' scores from the accumulated score. During this phase, the experts are able to access their own reviews via the 'All tasks' tab in the evaluation IT system and are able to leave a comment, if they wish, when accessing and submitting the 'Approve panel ranking' task.

The panel report - In addition to the ranked list of proposals, the panel report briefly documents the evaluation methodology followed by the panel. It may also contain, as deemed appropriate, reflections on issues such as the quality of proposals in relation to the call budget and other observations on the proposals or the evaluation process, as well as recommendations for future evaluations to the ERC Scientific Council.

5. FEEDBACK TO APPLICANTS (THE EVALUATION REPORT)

Apart from recommendations on fundable proposals and their ranking, the most important output of the evaluation process is the feedback to applicants. According to the [ERC Rules of submission and evaluation under Horizon Europe](#), the ERCEA will provide an Evaluation Report to each applicant, which documents the results of the evaluation process.

Especially in the case of rejection, the Evaluation Report needs to convey a comprehensive explanation of the fate of the proposal and the position of the panel with regard to it. The Evaluation Report of each proposal is composed of three elements: (i) the recommendation of the panel (according to the ranking list and the available call budget), (ii) the ranking range of the proposal among all the proposals evaluated by the panel and (iii) a compilation of the individual reviews by evaluation element including the final marks for each element ('pass' or 'fail').

The comments by experts are included in the Evaluation Report as received. The ERCEA will not change the content of the individual reviews, except if necessary to improve readability or, exceptionally, to remove any clerical errors or inappropriate comments, provided such errors or comments do not affect the evaluation results. The individual comments may not necessarily be convergent - differences of opinion about the merits of a proposal are legitimate among experts, and it is potentially useful for an applicant to be informed of the various views. After the remote evaluation phase, the ERC PoC call coordinator may contact the expert for clarification if necessary and may also alert the expert if a potential irregularity is spotted by the ERCEA, which would necessitate the revision of a comment or of a mark.

6. ELECTRONIC TOOLS USED IN EVALUATION

During remote evaluation, experts work individually using the on-line Commission's Submission and Evaluation of Proposals System tool ([SEP](#)).

Useful information on SEP is reported here: [Quick Guide on SEP Evaluation tool](#).

Detailed procedures and instructional video presentations on the usage of the SEP evaluation tool are available [here](#).

Information on EU Login is available [here](#).

ANNEX 1 – EVALUATION FORM

Criterion 1 – Breakthrough Innovation potential

Does the proposed idea have the potential to drive innovation and business inventiveness and/or tackle societal challenges?

Are the proposed expected outcomes innovative or distinctive compared to existing solutions?

Is the proposed idea high risk-high gain? If successful, will the outcome result in a breakthrough innovation? Is there a risk that some aspects are difficult to overcome?

Criterion 2 – Approach and methodology

Are the proposed activities and planning appropriate and effective to explore the pathway from ground-breaking research towards innovation? Activities may include:

- testing, experimenting, demonstrating and validating the idea;
- conducting research required to carry out the above activities and to address the weaknesses uncovered by them;
- clarifying IPR protection or knowledge transfer strategy;
- involving industry partners, societal or cultural organisations, policymakers or any other potential stakeholder supporting the translation of research results into innovation;
- assessing potential “end users” of the expected innovation.

Are the proposed timescales and resources adequate for the implementation and feasibility of the project, and properly justified? Will the activities be conducted by persons well qualified for the purpose?

Criterion 3: Principal Investigator - strategic lead and project management

Does the PI demonstrate a clear vision on how to manage the project, the consolidation of information and data needed to take strategic decisions and implement the proposed plan, including risk and contingency measures?